designed to give us an educational background upto graduation level, though in those days we never got any formal degrees.

The overall aim of training was character building, esprit de corps, mental and physical robustness, leadership and a sense of keen observation. Besides this one learnt inter-services aspects of the armed forces, developed interest in extracurricular activities, and inculcated the spirit of the 'honour code' as well as ethical and moral values. We were obliged to study a foreign language as an additional subject. The popular languages were French, German or Italian. However, I was allotted Arabic. By the end of our course, I had achieved a fairly good standard in this language and even passed the advanced diploma Part I exam. There were some clever guys who never passed their basic Hindi test and therefore, did not have to study a foreign language. They were losers in the long run, as I believe knowing another language is an asset in life.

When I joined the NDA, I was nominated to the Alpha squadron, but on rejoining after the first-term break, I was astonished to learn that my squadron had been changed to Juliet. This was a new squadron and cadets had to be transferred from all other squadrons to make it full strength. Being a new squadron, we had to forge ourselves into a team and soon we began to make a mark by excelling in various inter-squadron competitions. By the end of my stay in the NDA, we were amongst the best squadrons of the academy. As of now, there have been many two- and three-star generals, air marshals and admirals from the Juliet squadron, though I have been the only cadet to become a chief.

For relaxation, we used to look forward to the weekly movie. On occasions there was a dose of ragging and punishment at the end of the cinema show, if any of us misbehaved, whistled or jeered during it. We also used to have end-of-the-term social evenings, which were a cause of much amusement. We were permitted to go on an outing to Poona on Sundays or holidays and this was referred to as 'liberty'. Many of us got into serious problems getting back to the academy on time. Stopping of liberty was a very effective punishment. Studies were taken very seriously and we had to report back earlier for a retest in case we failed in two or more subjects. Only once